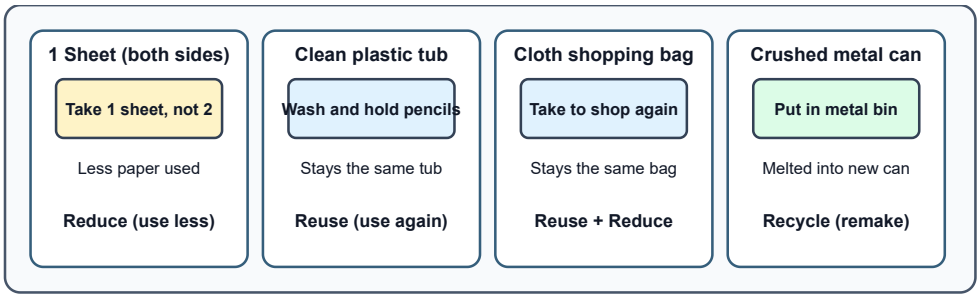
Reference sheets

Reference A · Classroom waste examples

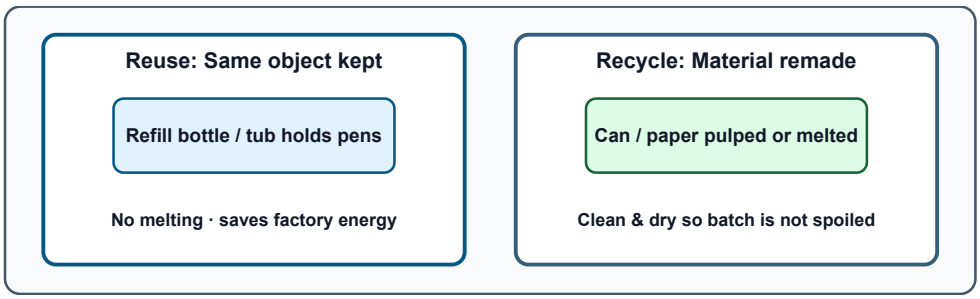


Four classroom waste items compared across action, object clue, and waste route.

Reference only. Do not write on this sheet. Use both clue columns to choose reduce, reuse, or recycle.

Classroom item	What we do with it	What happens to the object	Waste route	Why it helps
One sheet of paper (both sides)	Write on side 1 and side 2	We take 1 sheet instead of 2 at the start	Reduce	Saves new paper before waste is made
Clean plastic tub	Wash it and store pencils on the desk	Stays the same plastic tub	Reuse	No new pot needed and no factory melting
Cloth shopping bag	Carry shopping in it many times	Stays the same cloth bag	Reuse (and Reduce)	Replaces single-use plastic bags
Crushed metal drink can	Put clean and dry into the metal bin	Melted at a factory into new metal	Recycle	Saves digging up new metal ore

Reference B · How to tell reuse and recycle apart



Reuse keeps the same object without melting; recycle remakes clean, dry material at a factory.

Check question	Reuse	Recycle
Does the item stay the same object?	Yes — the tub stays a tub; the bottle stays a bottle	No — the can or paper is broken down and remade
Does it need factory melting or pulping?	No — wash or refill and use again straight away	Yes — uses factory heat, water, and energy
What preparation is needed?	Keep clean and safe to use again	Empty, rinse, and dry so food does not spoil the batch

Made by Matt

Tier pack · Aspire

Use Reference A and Reference B. Work in your book or on this sheet. Point, speak, sign, draw, type, write, or tell an adult. You may pass.

Arrival · 4 questions

1. Use the picture. How do Tray A and Tray B both stop us needing new items?

Help: Explain what new item is saved on Tray A and on Tray B.

2. Why must animals eat plants or other animals to stay alive?

Help: Link eating to energy and body materials.

3. Why do muscles work by pulling on bones rather than pushing them?

Help: Think about how a muscle shortens when it contracts.

4. What should we check before we reuse a plastic tub like the one on Tray B?

Help: Think about hygiene and sharp edges.

You do tasks

1. Use Reference A. Sort the four items (sheet with blank back, clean tub, cloth bag, empty metal can) into Reduce, Reuse, or Recycle. Staff I ☐ S ☐ C ☐

Help: Check which item uses less, which two are used again as they are, and which one becomes new metal.

2. A clean cloth bag is ready for another trip. Explain why using the cloth bag again is better than taking a new bag. Staff I ☐ S ☐ C ☐

Help: Use the words reuse and material in your explanation.

3. Before you reuse a tub or put a can into a recycling bin, what two checks must you make? Staff I ☐ S ☐ C ☐

Help: Check Reference B for the safety check and the local bin check.

4. Explain the difference between reusing a clean plastic tub and recycling it. Staff I ☐ S ☐ C ☐

Help: Think about whether the tub keeps its shape or gets broken down into new items.

5. Why does the waste guide put Reduce (use less) and Reuse (use again) before Recycle? Staff I ☐ S ☐ C ☐

Help: Look at Reference B. Think about whether recycling still uses energy and transport.

Exit ticket

1. How are reuse and recycle different, even though both help reduce waste?

2. Why is refilling one clean water bottle better than recycling five single-use bottles?

3. Why must we only reuse items that are clean and checked by an adult?

Made by Matt

Teacher answers and topic guidance

Accept any scientifically equivalent wording in spoken, signed, pointed, drawn, or written form.

Starter answer

Option A (Reuse). Washing a plastic tub and keeping pencils in it uses the same tub again without melting or remaking the plastic.

Arrival · Supported

1. Tray B shows a clean tub holding pencils.
2. Animals get food from what they eat.
3. Muscles pull on bones to help us move.
4. Yes. We can write on the blank back to use less paper.

Arrival · Independent

1. Tray A shows a paper sheet with a blank back.
2. Animals get food from what they eat, while green plants make their own food using light.
3. The skeleton holds the body up and muscles pull on bones so we can move.
4. Using the clean tub again holds pencils without needing to buy or make a new tub.

Arrival · Aspire

1. Tray A uses the blank back so we take no new paper, and Tray B reuses a clean tub so we need no new pot.
2. Animals cannot make their own food, so they must eat to get energy and materials for their bodies.
3. A muscle can contract and pull a bone across a joint, so another muscle pulls it back.
4. We must check that the tub is clean and has no sharp or broken edges.

You do · Supported mark scheme

1. The paper with a blank back matches Reduce (use less). *(Up to 2 marks)*
2. We can reuse the clean tub to hold pencils, or reuse the cloth bag to carry books. *(Up to 2 marks)*
3. I can use the tub again because it is clean and safe. *(Up to 2 marks)*

You do · Independent mark scheme

1. Reduce: sheet with blank back. Reuse: clean tub and cloth bag. Recycle: empty metal can (after checking local bin rules). *(Up to 3 marks)*
2. Using the cloth bag again is reuse. It saves new material because we do not need to make a fresh bag. *(Up to 3 marks)*
3. First check that the item is clean and has no sharp edges. Second check the local bin label to see if that material is accepted. *(Up to 2 marks)*

You do · Choice mark scheme

1. 1. Reduce (use less). 2. Reuse (use again). *(Up to 2 marks)*
2. 3. Metal. 4. Local bin label. *(Up to 2 marks)*
3. Use a clean cloth bag again because it is clean and needs no new material. *(Up to 2 marks)*

You do · Aspire challenge mark scheme

1. Reusing keeps the same clean tub and uses it again without changing it. Recycling breaks the old plastic down at a factory to make a new item. *(Up to 2 marks)*
2. Using less and reusing a safe item stop waste right away without needing lorries and factory energy to melt and remake the material. *(Up to 2 marks)*

Exit ticket · Supported

1. That is Reduce (use less).
2. Yes. That is reuse.
3. We check the local bin label.

Exit ticket · Independent

1. Reduce: write on the blank back of a sheet. Reuse: fill a clean tub with pencils or use a clean cloth bag again.
2. Material means what a thing is made of, such as metal in a can or paper in a sheet.
3. Different places accept different materials, and the wrong item can spoil the recycling load.

Exit ticket · Aspire

1. Reuse uses the same clean item again as it is, while recycle processes old material into a new product.
2. Refilling reduces the number of new bottles made and avoids the energy needed to collect and reprocess five bottles.
3. An unchecked waste item could be dirty or have sharp edges that could hurt someone.

Topic guidance and common misconceptions

- **Reuse vs recycle:** Pupils often call any positive environmental action 'recycling'. Emphasise the object test: if the bottle or tub stays the same object, it is **reuse**; if a factory melts or pulps the material to make a new thing, it is **recycle**.
- **Why reduce and reuse come first:** Recycling still uses collection trucks, heat, water, and electricity. Reducing and reusing save both raw materials and factory processing energy.
- **Clean and dry sorting:** Food or liquid left inside containers can spoil a whole load of paper or card in a recycling bin.

Made by Matt